BJP, the joke was that the former BJP president wanted to just mark his presence ahead of the Cabinet formation. ‘Everyone was already eyeing meaty portfolios,’ a BJP leader claimed later. Modi, as always, wasn’t revealing too much. He instead suggested that a wider consultation could begin on the road ahead. ‘I can come down to Delhi if you want,’ he had indicated to Gadkari. Gadkari had got the message. Forty-eight hours later, he along with party president Rajnath Singh and senior leader Arun Jaitley were winging their way to Gandhinagar. Significantly, Sushma Swaraj wasn’t present, while Advani had been ignored altogether. The balance of power within the party was now firmly ensconced in and around Modi. He didn’t need to come to Delhi—Delhi would come to his doorstep.

The four leaders held a preliminary discussion on government formation and what would be a possible calendar of events in the next fortnight. ‘We didn’t discuss who would be getting what portfolio, but we did look at the larger political picture that would emerge after the verdict. And yes, the assumption was that we were winning the elections,’ Jaitley later told me. If the BJP was eyeing power after ten years, the Congress was slowly reconciling itself to defeat. The party was now clutching at straws. ‘Do you really think we will get less than 100 seats?’ one minister asked me anxiously.

On 14 May, two days before the verdict, Sonia Gandhi threw a farewell dinner for Dr Singh and his wife. The prime minister had announced his retirement in January and this was an opportunity for the party to simply say thank you. It was a thoughtful gesture by Sonia and almost all the Union ministers and CWC members were there. A lavish spread had been prepared (one minister told me the kebabs were excellent). Dr Singh was presented with a silver plaque and a citation signed by all his Cabinet colleagues and there was a shawl for Gursharan Kaur. The Congress released a two-minute video thanking Dr Singh for ten years of leadership. If there had been any recrimination over things that had gone wrong, it appeared that at least for this one evening, they had been forgotten.

And yet, what should have been a special moment for the Congress party and Dr Singh was hijacked by the news that Rahul Gandhi was absent from